The Great Law of Peace

Haudenosaunee (Iroquois) Confederacy · founded c. 1450 (pre-contact)

Source: Arthur C. Parker, The Constitution of the Five Nations (New York State Museum Bulletin 184, 1916), text via archive.org. Public domain.

Long before European contact, five nations — the Mohawk, Oneida, Onondaga, Cayuga, and Seneca (joined by the Tuscarora c. 1722) — united under a single Great Law of Peace to form the Haudenosaunee, or Iroquois, Confederacy. A council of chiefs (sachems) governed by consensus. The Confederacy demonstrates the political sophistication and lasting institutions of Indigenous North America centuries before Europeans arrived. Preserved orally for generations, the law was written down only much later.

Connect: How does the Great Law challenge the idea that complex, organized government "began" in North America with European colonization?

Key Passages

Planting the Tree of Peace

I am Dekanawidah and with the Five Nations' Confederate Lords I plant the Tree of the Great Peace. … There shall you sit and watch the Council Fire of the Confederacy of the Five Nations, and all the affairs of the Five Nations shall be transacted at this place before you, Adodarhoh, and your cousin Lords, by the Confederate Lords of the Five Nations.

Removing a chief

If at any time it shall be manifest that a Confederate Lord has not in mind the welfare of the people or disobeys the rules of this Great Law, the men or the women of the Confederacy, or both jointly, shall come to the Council and upbraid the erring Lord through his War Chief. … The War Chiefs shall then divest the erring Lord of his title by order of the women in whom the titleship is vested. … The women will then select another of their sons as a candidate and the Lords shall elect him.

The duty of the chiefs

The thickness of their skin shall be seven spans — which is to say that they shall be proof against anger, offensive actions and criticism. … With endless patience they shall carry out their duty and their firmness shall be tempered with a tenderness for their people. … In all of your deliberations in the Confederate Council, in your efforts at law making, in all your official acts, self interest shall be cast into oblivion.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	Before European contact (c. 1450), the Mohawk, Oneida, Onondaga, Cayuga, and Seneca ended generations of warfare by uniting under one law, forming the Haudenosaunee (Iroquois) Confederacy.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	The member nations and their chiefs (sachems), clan mothers, and people, who passed the law down orally; it was written down for outsiders only in the early 1900s (Parker, 1916).

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	From the perspective of the Haudenosaunee themselves, preserved through oral tradition; the English text is a later transcription and translation, so some wording reflects the recorders.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ practice (A·C·E): Identify ONE way the Great Law shows political complexity in pre-contact North America.
2. What qualities does the Great Law expect of its leaders, and why might those matter for a confederacy?
3. Why is a source preserved orally for generations both valuable and challenging for historians to use?

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The Haudenosaunee (Iroquois) Confederacy

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> The founding constitution of the Iroquois Confederacy, uniting five (later six) nations under a "Tree of Great Peace." Its federal structure and ideas of unity and representation are often cited as an influence on later American government.

Planting the Tree of Peace (Law 1)

I am Dekanawidah and with the Five Nations' Confederate Lords I plant the Tree of the Great Peace. I plant it in your territory, Adodarhoh, and the Onondaga Nation, in the territory of you who are Firekeepers. I name the tree the Tree of the Great Long Leaves. Under the shade of this Tree of the Great Peace we spread the soft white feathery down of the globe thistle as seats for you, Adodarhoh, and your cousin Lords. We place you upon those seats, spread soft with the feathery down of the globe thistle, there beneath the shade of the spreading branches of the Tree of Peace. There shall you sit and watch the Council Fire of the Confederacy of the Five Nations, and all the affairs of the Five Nations shall be transacted at this place before you, Adodarhoh, and your cousin Lords, by the Confederate Lords of the Five Nations.

[. . .]

The Great White Roots (Law 2)

Roots have spread out from the Tree of the Great Peace, one to the north, one to the east, one to the south and one to the west. The name of these roots is The Great White Roots and their nature is Peace and Strength. If any man or any nation outside the Five Nations shall obey the laws of the Great Peace and make known their disposition to the Lords of the Confederacy, they may trace the Roots to the Tree and if their minds are clean and they are obedient and promise to obey the wishes of the Confederate Council, they shall be welcomed to take shelter beneath the Tree of the Long Leaves. We place at the top of the Tree of the Long Leaves an Eagle who is able to see afar. If he sees in the distance any evil approaching or any danger threatening he will at once warn the people of the Confederacy.

[. . .]

How the council decides (Law 9)

All the business of the Five Nations Confederate Council shall be conducted by the two combined bodies of Confederate Lords. First the question shall be passed upon by the Mohawk and Seneca Lords, then it shall be discussed and passed by the Oneida and Cayuga Lords. Their decisions shall then be referred to the Onondaga Lords, (Fire Keepers) for final judgment.

[. . .]

Removing a chief who fails the people (Law 19)

If at any time it shall be manifest that a Confederate Lord has not in mind the welfare of the people or disobeys the rules of this Great Law, the men or the women of the Confederacy, or both jointly, shall come to the Council and upbraid the erring Lord through his War Chief. If the complaint of the people through the War Chief is not heeded the first time it shall be uttered again and then if no attention is given a third complaint and warning shall be given. If the Lord is still contumacious the matter shall go to the council of War Chiefs. . . . The War Chiefs shall then divest the erring Lord of his title by order of the women in whom the titleship is vested. When the Lord is deposed the women shall notify the Confederate Lords through their War Chief, and the Confederate Lords shall sanction the act. The women will then select another of their sons as a candidate and the Lords shall elect him.

[. . .]

The duty of the chiefs (Law 24)

The Lords of the Confederacy of the Five Nations shall be mentors of the people for all time. The thickness of their skin shall be seven spans — which is to say that they shall be proof against anger, offensive actions and criticism. Their hearts shall be full of peace and good will and their minds filled with a yearning for the welfare of the people of the Confederacy. With endless patience they shall carry out their duty and their firmness shall be tempered with a tenderness for their people. Neither anger nor fury shall find lodgement in their minds and all their words and actions shall be marked by calm deliberation.

[. . .]

Installing a new chief (Law 28)

We now do crown you with the sacred emblem of the deer's antlers, the emblem of your Lordship. You shall now become a mentor of the people of the Five Nations. The thickness of your skin shall be seven spans — which is to say that you shall be proof against anger, offensive actions and criticism. . . . In all of your deliberations in the Confederate Council, in your efforts at law making, in all your official acts, self interest shall be cast into oblivion.

[. . .]

Descent through the mother (Law 44)

The lineal descent of the people of the Five Nations shall run in the female line. Women shall be considered the progenitors of the Nation. They shall own the land and the soil. Men and women shall follow the status of the mother.

[. . .]

Burying the weapons of war (Law 65)

I, Dekanawida, and the Union Lords, now uproot the tallest pine tree and into the cavity thereby made we cast all weapons of war. Into the depths of the earth, down into the deep underearth currents of water flowing to unknown regions we cast all the weapons of strife. We bury them from sight and we plant again the tree. Thus shall the Great Peace be established and hostilities shall no longer be known between the Five Nations but peace to the United People.

Words to know

Confederate Lords — the chiefs who sit on the council of the Five Nations league

upbraid — scold or formally rebuke

contumacious — stubbornly refusing to obey

divest — strip away; remove the Lord's title from him

lineal descent — the family line through which membership and rank are inherited

progenitors — ancestors; the source from which the nation descends